

BHAJJU SHYAM, 51

Artist, Gond tribe

In 1994, Bhajju came from Patangarh in Madhya Pradesh's Dindori district to Bhopal looking for a job. While in the alien city, he lived with pioneering Gond artist Jangarh Singh Shyam. With his encouragement, Bhajju began painting and, within the next three years, carved a niche for himself. In 2001, some months after Jangarh's tragic suicide, Bhajju was commissioned to paint the walls of a London restaurant. On his return, the series of paintings he made on life in the UK capital as he saw it were compiled into *The London Jungle Book*. Bhajju has since authored 16 more books. He received the Padma Shri in 2018.

"OUR LIVES ARE CLOSELY INTERTWINED WITH NATURE. OUR ASSOCIATION WITH NATURE IS REFLECTED IN OUR ART TOO"

Photograph by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR